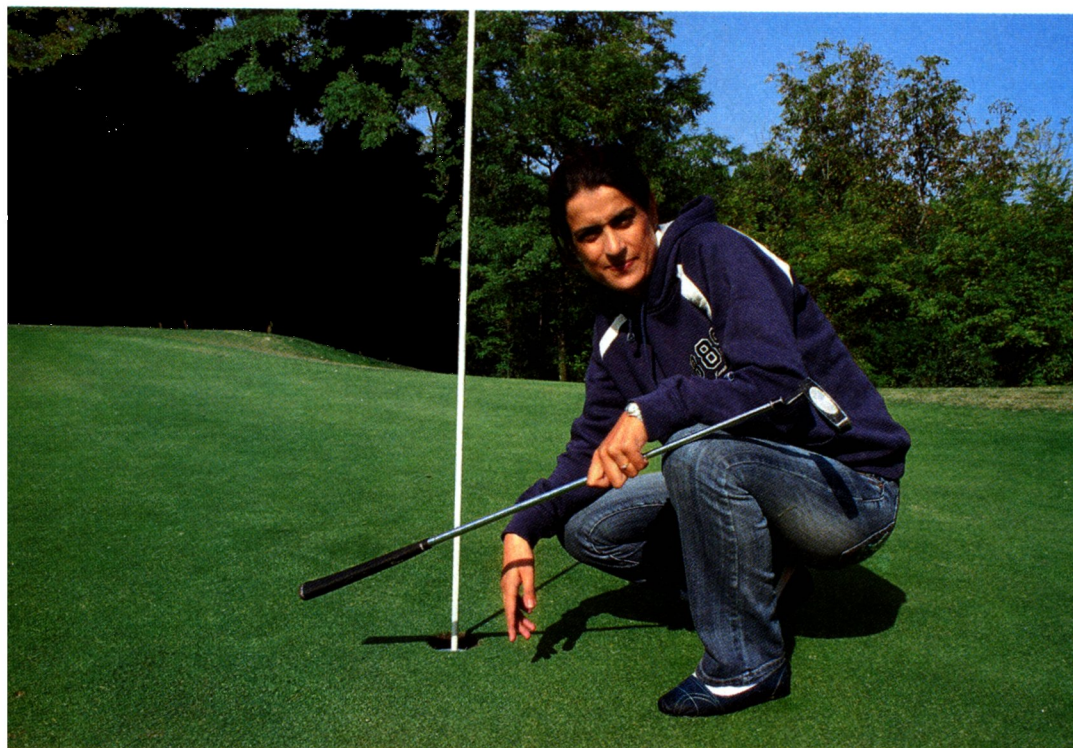


Club Class

A golf course holds one of Kashmir's best kept secrets—India's only woman turf manager



**GUL AT HER
WORKPLACE**

By Bhavna Vij-Aurora

have encroached into men's territory," laughs Nuzhat Gul. The 34-year-old petite Kashmiri has broken many a stereotype to become the first woman turf manager in the country, successfully nurturing the Royal Springs Golf Course in Srinagar for the past eight years. Being the only woman in a male-dominated turf is no big deal for her anymore. After all, Gul was tough enough to take up the job after the American turf manager fled in the wake of the Kargil War in 1999. At the masters course in Turf Management at the University of Massachusetts in 2008, she was the lone woman in a class of 65. "Boys would not take me seriously. But one day, when I gave a presentation on my golf course to the class, they were awe-struck," she says with pride. She returned to her job in Srinagar with a gold medal.

Gul shunned all campus placements. "I was told that I was a fool, not taking up offers as managing a turf is big money abroad. But I wanted to return to my homeland," she says. She even turned down a \$6,000-per-month offer to manage a golf turf in Hyderabad. Her

initial days were not easy as people could not digest a pretty woman, in a torn pair of jeans and a T-shirt doing manual labour in the greens. Gul had to deal with everyone, right from the plumber and gardeners to the engineers and HR people. She had a team of 84 men under her and was forced to talk tough. "Only then they realised that I had the stomach of a man," the articulate Gul says. Then there were people who wanted her out as she was rubbing shoulders with heads of state, chief ministers and other dignitaries. Once they saw that she meant business, they accepted her with respect.

Gul grew up in the orchards of Shopian, southern Kashmir. Her father was an agrostologist, a person who studies grasses, and she herself studied landscaping and floriculture from Punjab Agriculture University, Ludhiana. Her's is not a regular job as it requires round-the-clock monitoring, odd timings and travel. It is the support from her husband and in-laws who look after her two children which allows her "to work in peace" in a state that remains in the news for its conflict. ■